DATA STORY · WORLD BANK NET MIGRATION

Migration and History: 1962–2012

READING NOTE

How to read the data

Net migration = in − out

A positive value means the country gained migrants; a negative value means it lost them.

Each column is 5 years

Values are UN five-year period estimates: the 1962 column ≈ 1960–65, the 2012 column ≈ 2010–15.

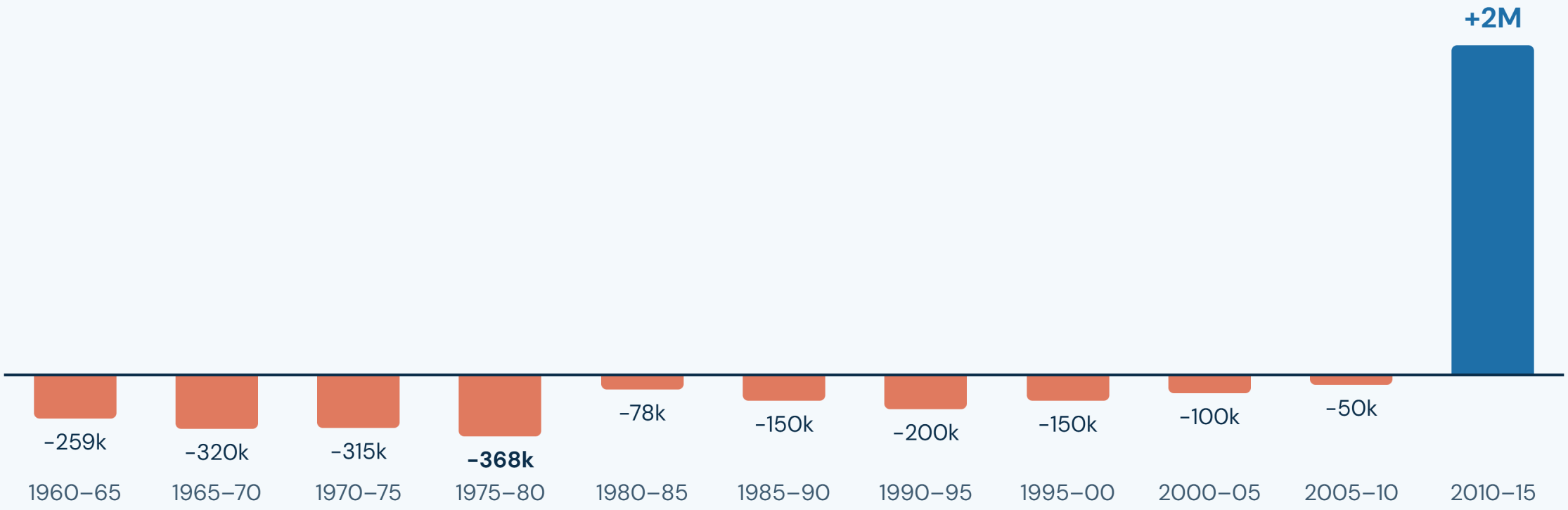
Most values are estimates

Round numbers such as −150,000 or +2,000,003 are model estimates, not measurements.

Blue: net inflow (+) Coral: net outflow (−) Darker shades mean larger volumes.

Türkiye lost migrants for 50 years, then gained over 2 million in 2010–15

Net migration, 5-year period totals · Total outflow 1960–2010: -2.0 million · 2011: Syrian civil war



Türkiye's migration history in five periods

1960–75

−320k

Labor migration to Europe

1961 labor agreement with Germany, followed by Austria, the Netherlands, Belgium and France.

1975–80

−368k

Peak

Germany stopped recruiting workers in 1973, but family reunification kept people leaving.

1980–85

−78k

Sharp drop

Hundreds of thousands returned under Germany's 1983 return incentive law.

1985–95

−200k

Rising again

Terrorist incidents in the southeast raised asylum applications; in 1989, ~300k ethnic Turks arrived from Bulgaria.

2010–15

+2M

A destination country

With the Syrian civil war, Türkiye became the world's largest refugee-hosting country.

Small relative to population: the annual net migration rate was **−1.00‰** in the 20th century and **+1.74‰** in the 21st.

Whenever Türkiye lost migrants, Germany gained them

Net migration, 5-year period totals · Germany over 50 years: +9.6 million

	1960–65	1965–70	1970–75	1975–80	1980–85	1985–90	1990–95	1995–00	2000–05	2005–10	2010–15
Türkiye	-259k	-320k	-315k	-368k	-78k	-150k	-200k	-150k	-100k	-50k	+2M
Germany	+667k	+918k	+714k	+289k	+23 people	+1.71M	+3.23M	+744k	+1k	+32k	+1.25M

1960–75 · Guest workers

When the Berlin Wall cut off its labor supply, West Germany recruited workers from Italy, Greece, Spain, Türkiye and Yugoslavia.

1985–95 · The largest wave

The fall of the Eastern Bloc and 1990 reunification brought ethnic Germans (Aussiedler) and Yugoslav war refugees.

2010–15 · Both gained migrants

Southern Europeans fleeing the euro crisis moved to Germany; Syrian refugees came to Türkiye.

The US gained migrants every period; Mexico lost them

Net migration, 5-year period totals · Over 50 years: US +44.6 million, Mexico −13.1 million

	1960–65	1965–70	1970–75	1975–80	1980–85	1985–90	1990–95	1995–00	2000–05	2005–10	2010–15
US	+959k	+1.5M	+2.84M	+3.87M	+3.28M	+3.69M	+4.57M	+8.69M	+5.15M	+5.07M	+5.01M
Mexico	−411k	−620k	−900k	−1.21M	−1.52M	−1.54M	−1.3M	−1.84M	−2.84M	−410k	−524k

1965 · Hart–Celler Act

Quotas favoring Europe were abolished; US net inflow rose to +3.9 million by 1975–80.

1986 Amnesty Act and the 1990s

~3 million people got legal status. The US peaked in 1995–2000; Mexico's outflow peaked in 2000–05 after NAFTA and the peso crisis.

2008 Crisis

Mexico's net outflow fell back to −410k while the US held at about 5 million; the center of gravity of migration shifted to Asia.

RUSSIA AND THE FORMER SOVIET STATES

The 1991 breakup: the largest structural break in the data

+4.8M

Russia, 1990–2000: Russians returned from the new states

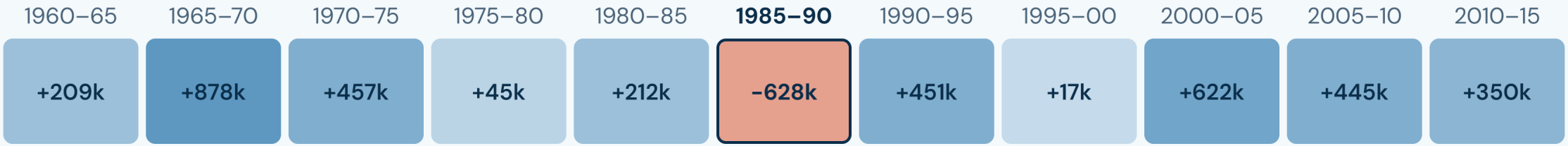
−2.8M

Kazakhstan, 1990–2000: lost its Russians and ethnic Germans

Thirty years earlier it was the reverse: in 1960–65 Russia lost 1.4 million while Kazakhstan gained +692k through the “Virgin Lands” campaign.

Japan gained a few migrants in 10 of 11 periods

The only negative period was 1985–90: -628k



Stable relative to population

-628k in a population of 122 million is about -1‰ a year; other periods mostly stay within ±1‰.

A possible explanation

After the 1985 Plaza Accord the yen rose and production moved abroad, but this explains only a small part of the drop.

Treat with caution

Neighboring periods are +212k and +451k; a one-period reversal like this may also be an estimate revision.

Four of the top 5 source countries are in Asia

Their large populations keep the rates low

Country	Net, 50 years	Key break
Bangladesh	-14.6M	1971 Liberation War: -3.0M in 1970–75; labor migration to the Gulf: -3.6M in 2005–10
China	-10.5M	~-2M every period in 2000–15; only ~-0.3‰ a year
Philippines	-6.2M	Outflow peaked at -1.8M in 2005–10
India	-5.6M	+2.1M in 1970–75 (refugees from Bangladesh); -0.7M to -2.8M every period after 1990
Afghanistan	-3.6M	1979 Soviet invasion: -3.4M in 1980–85; +2.2M returned in 1990–95

In the Middle East, wars and oil drove migration

The world's highest rates relative to population are here

Wars

−4.0M	Syria, 2010–15: civil war
+1.25M	Lebanon, same period: a quarter of its population
+370k	Syria, 2005–10: refuge for fleeing Iraqis
−581k	Kuwait, 1990–95: Iraqi invasion

Oil and construction

+1.4M	Saudi Arabia, 1980–85
+3.5M	UAE, 2005–10: Dubai construction boom
+855k	Qatar, 2005–10
+77‰	Qatar's annual net migration rate, the world's highest in the 21st century

CONCLUSION

Wars and policies create the breaks; economic gaps set the long-term direction.

Wars

Short, sharp spikes: Afghanistan, Syria, Kuwait.

Policies

They start and stop long trends: the 1961 labor agreement, the 1965 US act, the 1973 recruitment stop.

Europe’s reversal

Spain gained +2.8M in 2000–05, then swung to -593k in 2010–15.

Limits and source

- ⚠ Values are UN five-year estimates; irregular migration and temporary refugee movements may not be fully captured.
- 🔗 Matching with events shows association, not causation.
- 🔍 Unexplained values such as Japan's 1985–90 figure should be verified separately.

Data

World Bank net migration, 1962–2012

World Bank population data

Event dates are based on general historical knowledge.